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Skullcaps and turbans

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C. The congregation: its whole and its parts .

This habitual gathering in the afternoon is referred to by the villagers, with some slight irony, as “the j_ema't” of the village, that is, its congregation. These old men are not, strictly speaking “the” j_ema't, but rather are only a part of it. Nevertheless they are a sufficiently powerful and influential part of it for the joke of calling them by its name to have a telling effect.

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Around 4 p.m., that is, at the time of the 'asr prayer, the “turbans” in the mosque usually share a platter of barley grits and buttermilk, provided by one of them in turn. Then, as the afternoon begins to wane, the attendance at the mosque begins to swell as other mature men begin filtering back home from their various day's tasks, and they go to sit with “the j_ema't” for a while, anticipating the  214 evening prayer.

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